

Federal Court Dockets Cited in Outer-Space and UAP Theories

A public-record briefing of the cases researchers and online “outer space theory” channels most often treat as Department of Justice dockets — plus the actual space-industry cases in which DOJ is a party.

Prepared 2026-09-20 · Sources: PACER / CourtListener, DOJ press releases, published opinions, FOIA litigation dockets. Case captions and numbers should be re-checked before citation; dockets change.

1. How to read this packet

There is no official compilation titled “the DOJ dockets mentioned in outer space theories.” Online space / UAP channels mix three different kinds of records and often call all of them “DOJ dockets”:

A. True DOJ criminal or civil cases in which the United States, through the Department of Justice, is the prosecutor or a party (fraud against NASA, export-control cases, employment-discrimination actions against SpaceX, etc.).

B. FOIA lawsuits against NASA, NSA, CIA, DOD, or DOJ itself. These are civil cases in federal district court. DOJ’s Civil Division or U.S. Attorney’s Office usually defends the agency. Theorists treat withheld pages as proof of a space-program cover-up; the docket itself usually shows ordinary exemption fights (national security, deliberative process, law-enforcement).

C. Agency administrative files, FBI serials, and declassified archives (Project Blue Book, FBI HQ 62-83894 “Flying Saucers,” PURSUE / war.gov/ufo releases). These are *not* court dockets. They are investigative or archival files.

A “docket” is the court’s running log of filings in one case (complaint, motions, orders). PACER is the official paid system. CourtListener / RECAP republishes many of the same PDFs for free when someone has already pulled them.

2. The FOIA / secrecy cases UAP channels actually mean

These are the lawsuits that show up again and again when channels talk about “court records proving NASA / NSA hid space or UFO files.” What the docket shows is a records fight, not a finding that extraterrestrial craft exist.

Case / citation	What the docket actually is
Citizens Against UFO Secrecy v. NSA, Civ. No. 80-1562 (D.D.C. 1980)	FOIA demand for NSA UFO intercepts. NSA submitted the classified Eugene F. Yeates in-camera affidavit (Top Secret UMBRA). Court upheld withholding. Later partial releases after decades. This is the classic “NSA UFO court case” in the literature.
Kean / Coalition for Freedom of Information FOIA suit v. NASA (D.D.C., filed 2003; settled 2007)	Leslie Kean / SCI FI Channel suit over the 9 Dec 1965 Kecksburg, PA “acorn” object. Settlement required NASA to search and produce additional documents and pay fees. Search finished ~2009. No recovered craft was produced; theorists treat missing boxes as the story.
Informed Consent Action Network v. NASA, No. 1:24-cv-03062 (D.D.C.)	FOIA suit for communications of Riley Duren and Erik Conway on geoengineering / solar-radiation-management terms. Court granted NASA summary judgment. Circulates in “NASA weather / space weapon” threads more than classic saucer lore.
Leopold / Bloomberg v. DOJ, No. 1:22-cv-03009 (D.D.C.)	FOIA against DOJ components (OIP, NSD) and related agencies. Not a space case, but often cited as “DOJ hiding records” in mega-threads that also include UAP files.
Ongoing Black Vault / Greenwald NASA FOIA administrative cases (not all litigated)	Dozens of NASA FOIA case numbers (e.g., 22-HQ-F-00488 Bill Nelson emails containing UAP/UFO terms). Most never become dockets; they become production letters. When NASA stonewalls, they can become D.D.C. complaints.

Related non-docket archives that get mislabeled as dockets: FBI file 62-HQ-83894 (“Flying Saucers”); USAF Project Blue Book incident cards; AARO Historical Record Report Vol. 1 (March 2024); 2026 PURSUE releases at war.gov/ufo. Those are agency files, not PACER cases.

3. Real DOJ criminal and civil cases involving NASA or space contractors

These are genuine Department of Justice matters. Conspiracy channels sometimes recast contractor fraud or export cases as “they were punished for talking about hidden space tech.” The charging documents describe money, subcontracting rules, or export licenses — not recovered craft.

Matter	DOJ role and holding / charge
United States v. Yujie Ding & Yuliya Zotova, E.D. Pa.	Wire-fraud indictment over NASA SBIR awards to ArkLight for a purported single-photon detector tied to the ASCENDS lidar mission. Classic SBIR “work was not performed / improperly subcontracted” case. DOJ USAO-EDPA.
United States v. Ashok Saxena, No. 8:24-cr-00094 (D. Md.)	Information charging false statements (18 U.S.C. § 1001) that a company had a NASA subcontract requiring Top Secret clearance. Filed by DOJ Antitrust Division criminal section, March 2024.
NASA OIG / DCIS rocket-part fraud (D. Or., 3:18-cr-00168 and related)	Criminal follow-on after NASA rocket failures involving altered tensile-test results on aluminum extrusions / frangible joints. Civil NASA-OIG probe began ~2012; Fraud Section criminal case later.
United States v. Arabi, Espargham & Bayati (aerospace / satellite technology wire-fraud conspiracy)	DOJ indictment: scheme to defraud U.S. persons and entities in aerospace and satellite technology, ~2016–2019. 18 U.S.C. §§ 1343, 1349.
NASA OIG moon-rock / artifact stings — e.g., Davis v. United States, No. 5:13-cv-00483 (C.D. Cal.); related criminal recoveries	NASA treats Apollo lunar material and flown artifacts as U.S. property. Undercover OIG operations have recovered “moon rocks” offered for sale. Civil suits by sellers usually lose. Not a UFO docket; often listed next to “NASA seized the evidence.”
DOJ NSD declination re: Universities Space Research Association (USRA), 2025	Not a prosecution: National Security Division declined to prosecute USRA after an employee exported Army aviation software to a PRC Entity List university. Employee had already pleaded guilty (IEEPA). Shows how export-control space-adjacent cases are handled.

4. SpaceX dockets that get folded into “space theory” videos

Because SpaceX is the most visible U.S. launch company, its fights with the federal government are constantly dropped into UAP and “secret space fleet” narratives. The pleadings are about hiring, environmental review, coastal permits, and contracts.

Case	What it is
United States v. Space Exploration Technologies Corp. (C.D. Cal.) — administrative subpoena	DOJ Immigrant and Employee Rights (IER) investigation into whether SpaceX’s hiring discriminated against asylees and refugees. DOJ sought an order compelling compliance with an administrative subpoena. Related OCAHO matter: In re Investigation of SpaceX, 14 OCAHO no. 1378 (2020).
SpaceX v. Bell / IER ALJ, No. 1:23-cv-00137 (S.D. Tex.)	SpaceX sued to enjoin the IER administrative complaint as unconstitutional (ALJ structure). Follow-on to the hiring case above.
Center for Biological Diversity v. FAA, No. 1:23-cv-01204 (D.D.C.); SpaceX intervenor	NEPA challenge to FAA launch licensing. DOJ Environment and Natural Resources Division defends FAA. Court granted the government and SpaceX partial summary judgment (Sept. 2025 order on the docket).
SpaceX v. United States, No. 1:19-cv-00742 (Fed. Cl.)	Tucker Act bid-protest style complaint against the Air Force (DOJ represents the United States). Terminated 2019. Contract, not extraterrestrials.
SpaceX v. NLRB, No. 1:24-cv-00001 (S.D. Tex.) and related C.D. Cal. transfers	Constitutional challenge to NLRB structure. Recurring in “deep state vs. space company” commentary.

Case	What it is
Aguilar et al. v. SpaceX, No. 1:26-cv-00485 (S.D. Tex.)	Property-damage style mass action (Starship / Boca Chica operations). Private civil case; DOJ is not the plaintiff.

5. Fringe complaints that theorists treat as “the docket”

Federal courts also receive pro se complaints that track internet cosmology. These get screenshotted as if a judge accepted the underlying theory. Read the order, not the caption.

Hepburn v. United States / NASA — W.D. Okla. CIV-24-0026-HE (FTCA complaint) and the related qui tam *United States ex rel. Hepburn v. NASA*, CIV-23-586-J. Plaintiff alleged NASA spread false information that the Earth is a rotating sphere, that moon landings occurred, etc. The qui tam was dismissed as frivolous; the FTCA case was likewise treated as tracking those allegations. This is the “NASA sued for lying about space” exhibit in flat-earth and some UAP comment sections.

Moot-court and academic hypotheticals (e.g., Galactic Empire, Inc. v. Han Solo, “Sixteenth Circuit”) are not real dockets. They appear in law-school briefs about venue and the Commercial Space Launch Act and get mis-shared as live Supreme Court cases.

6. Space criminal jurisdiction — the statute theorists quote

When channels say “DOJ already has jurisdiction in outer space,” they are usually pointing at 18 U.S.C. § 7, the special maritime and territorial jurisdiction (SMTJ) statute — not at a secret docket.

§ 7(6) (added 1981) includes vehicles “used or designed for flight or navigation in space.” Congress said this closed a gap so U.S. criminal law could reach a U.S.-registered craft (then the Shuttle) in flight, consistent with the Outer Space Treaty rule that a state retains jurisdiction over objects on its registry. § 7(7) (1984) covers certain offenses by or against U.S. nationals in places outside the jurisdiction of any nation. Murder, manslaughter, and other SMTJ-applicable crimes can therefore be charged if the facts fit. CRS sidebar LSB10869 collects the doctrine. There is still no reported “space murder” conviction; the first widely discussed in-orbit allegation (ISS, 2019) was a ground-based access dispute, not an SMTJ trial.

7. How to pull the actual papers

- PACER (pacer.uscourts.gov): official docket. \$0.10/page cap \$3.00 per document; opinions free. Use the PACER Case Locator if you only have a party name.
- CourtListener / RECAP (courtlistener.com): free copies of many of the PDFs above once they have been purchased once.
- justice.gov press releases and USAO sites: charging documents for the fraud and export cases.
- NASA OIG semiannual reports: list of procurement and artifact cases that may not yet have a public indictment.
- NARA UAP Records Collection (NDAA FY2024 §§ 1841–1843) and war.gov/ufo (PURSUE, 2026–): declassified files, not dockets.
- The Black Vault and Disclosure Archives: indexed FOIA productions and case numbers for NASA/UAP email requests.

8. What these dockets do not show

No federal docket identified for this briefing contains a judicial finding that the United States recovered a non-human craft, operates a clandestine manned space fleet, or that NASA’s public missions are fabricated. AARO’s Historical Record Report Volume 1 states that U.S. investigations to date have not confirmed extraterrestrial technology and that many circulating “hidden program” claims resolve to ordinary classified aerospace work or to programs that do not exist. FOIA withholdings prove that an agency invoked an exemption; they do not prove the contents of the withheld page.

If you have a specific channel, video, or case number from “Outer Space Theories” (a caption, PACER number like 1:23-cv-01204, or a screenshot of a docket sheet), those identifiers can be matched one-for-one. Without that, the list above is the working set that appears in that genre.

This briefing is a finding aid, not a substitute for the record. Captions, judges, and dispositions change. Always open the live docket before relying on a case.